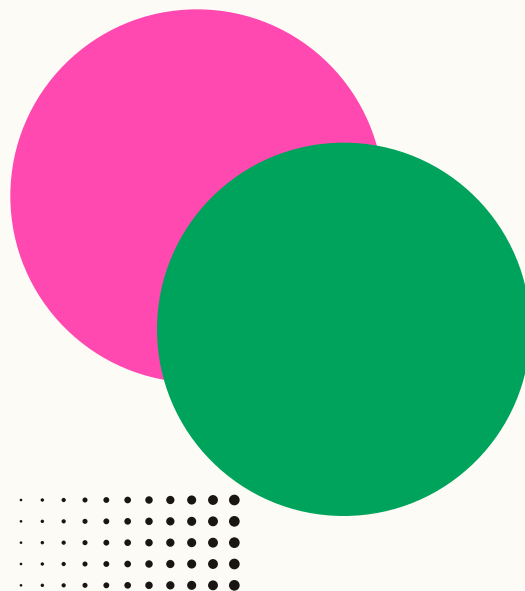


Brand Directions -- Round 2

Three different worlds, after precedent research. June 2026

NIGHT SURVEY

DIRECTION I



OVER- PRINT

DIRECTION II



Pigment Index

DIRECTION III

What we heard, and what changes

Round 1 presented three directions that were really three rooms of one house: the same cream paper, the same muted earth inks, the same almanac register at three volumes. All three also sat close to the site's current paper-and-green look. The owner asked for a real spread -- directions that disagree with each other.

Round 2 starts from research instead of taste: a survey of the best-designed sites adjacent to this mission, of cartographic registers, of contemporary craft print culture, and of where identity design is moving in 2026. Each direction now stakes a different claim on every axis that matters.

AXES FORCED APART THIS ROUND

GROUND

night spruce / press white / seasonal tint

TYPE REGISTER

luminous serif / wood-type poster / kinetic variable

IMAGERY ENGINE

data-as-light / stencil overprint / pigment fields

MAP TREATMENT

firefly / spot-ink poster / pigment dots

SEASON MECHANISM

light temperature / two-ink edition / tint + type drift

STILL GOVERNED BY THE BRIEF, IN ALL THREE

Expressive display + quiet text. Two owned imagery engines (SVG illustration, data-as-art). A seasonal living palette in CSS variables. Safety colors unmistakable and colorblind-distinguishable. Occurrence is never permission -- placed prominently, in every direction. No photography dependency. No twee, no institutional, no rustic kitsch.

PRECEDENT RESEARCH

Sites that share our mission

What the best-designed neighbors get right -- and the gap they leave.

Emergence Magazine STUDIO AIRPORT; WEBBY & EUROPEAN DESIGN AWARD WORK

Literary ecology with radical but disciplined art direction. Full-bleed immersion always paired with a calm library index to come home to.

Lesson: one expressive move per surface; immersion needs wayfinding.

Mushroom Color Atlas JULIE BEELER, WITH YULI GATES ILLUSTRATIONS

Dye swatches from fungi are the navigation itself -- click a color, reach the mushroom. Illustration and data are one system.

Lesson: let the material's own output (its color) be the interface.

Falling Fruit / iNaturalist THE DATA PLATFORMS THIS SITE DRAWS ON

Deep, trusted data with thin visual identity. Credible, institutional, and emotionally flat -- the gap Craft Almanac can own.

Lesson: data alone does not invite; identity must carry the warmth.

Native Land / Queering the Map COUNTER-MAPPING PROJECTS

Rendering choices read as values: what glows, what is withheld, what is named. Their maps argue; people feel it.

Lesson: 'occurrence is not permission' can be a designed moment, not a disclaimer in small print.

*the forest holds
its breath*



RICH DATA, THIN IDENTITY

PRECEDENT RESEARCH

Cartographic registers

Three ways a map can carry a brand.

Firefly cartography JOHN NELSON / ESRI; EARTH.NULLSCHOOL

Dark, desaturated basemaps with glowing thematic data. The technique makes ordinary point data feel alive and precious -- leaned-in, not scanned. nullschool became beloved infrastructure on atmosphere alone.

Lesson: the basemap is the brand. A custom map style is the single highest-leverage identity asset this site owns.

The paper survey register USGS QUADS, ALMANACS, THE CURRENT SITE

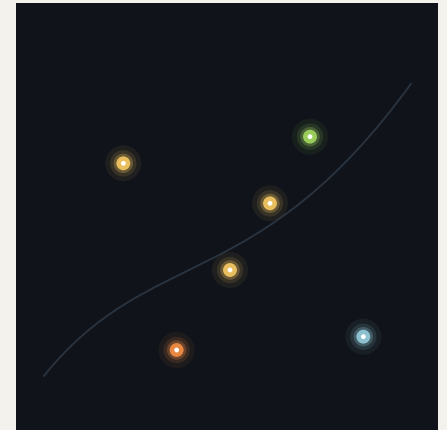
Warm, credible, familiar -- and so familiar it disappears. Round 1 lived here three times. Kept available as a register, not a default.

Lesson: paper must be pushed (scale, color, type) or abandoned.

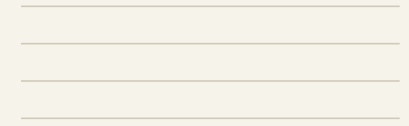
Color-field interfaces MUSHROOM COLOR ATLAS; ARCHIVE CATALOGS

Large fields of meaningful color organize without chrome. Works because the color is data, not decoration.

Lesson: material-derived palettes give us color no competitor can copy.



FIREFLY: DATA AS LIGHT



PAPER: WARM, INVISIBLE

PRECEDENT RESEARCH

Craft culture + 2026 currents

What contemporary craft looks like, and where identity design is moving.

Riso & print-studio culture RISOTTO, RISOLVE, PEOPLE OF PRINT'S 51 STUDIOS

Fluorescent two-ink overprints, visible misregistration, small-batch pride. This is what 'craft' looks like to contemporary makers -- joyful and hand-made without a single antique gesture.

Lesson: hands visible, never rustic. Overprint logic is also cheap in CSS (mix-blend-mode).

Craft schools on the web PENLAND, HAYSTACK, NORTH HOUSE

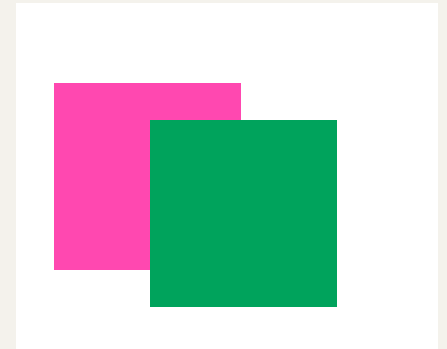
Beloved institutions, conventional websites: photo grids and quiet type. The workshop warmth dies in translation.

Lesson: an opening -- no one owns 'craft education' visually online.

2026 identity currents IT'S NICE THAT, CREATIVE BLOQ, FONTFABRIC, BRANDING JOURNAL

Type-as-hero and kinetic, stacked, poster-scale headlines. Adaptive identities that respond to context instead of staying fixed. Texture and tactile layering over flat sterility; serif resurgence in editorial. Warmth is the trend; polish for its own sake is not.

Lesson: an almanac that knows the season is exactly an adaptive identity -- our premise is current, our round-1 execution was not.



TWO INKS, THIRD COLOR FREE

MAKE
make
Make

TYPE AS THE HERO IMAGE

Five principles for Round 2

01 One expressive move per surface.

Emergence's discipline: each page gets one radical gesture; everything else stays quiet and legible.

02 The basemap is the brand.

A custom Mapbox style is our highest-leverage asset. Each direction restyles the map first, the chrome second.

03 Let materials supply the color.

Madder, weld, walnut, oak gall: palettes no competitor can copy, and color that teaches while it decorates.

04 Hands visible, never antique.

Contemporary craft reads as riso ink and confident cuts, not parchment. Texture yes; distressing never.

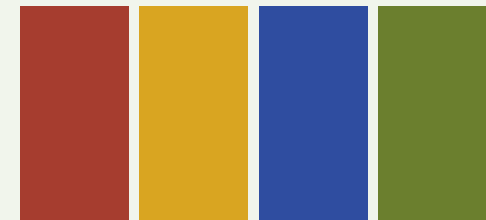
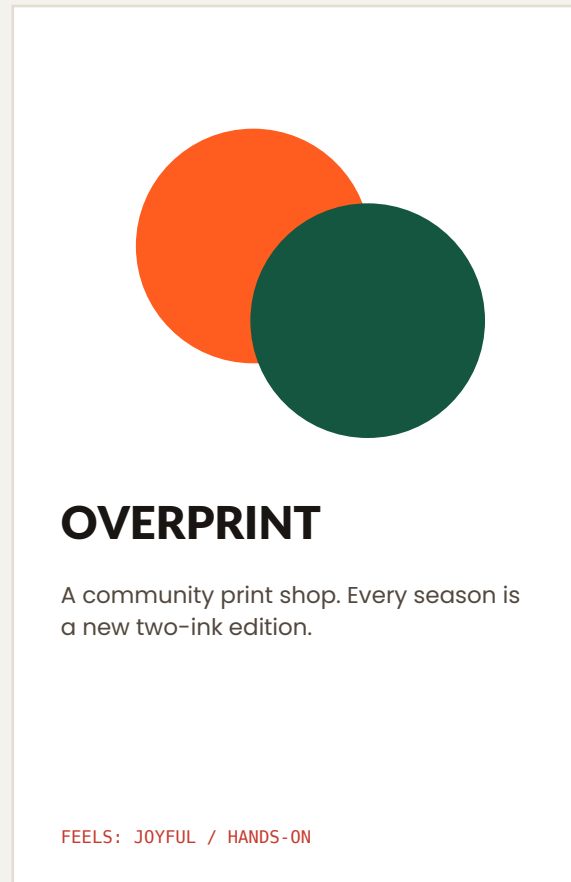
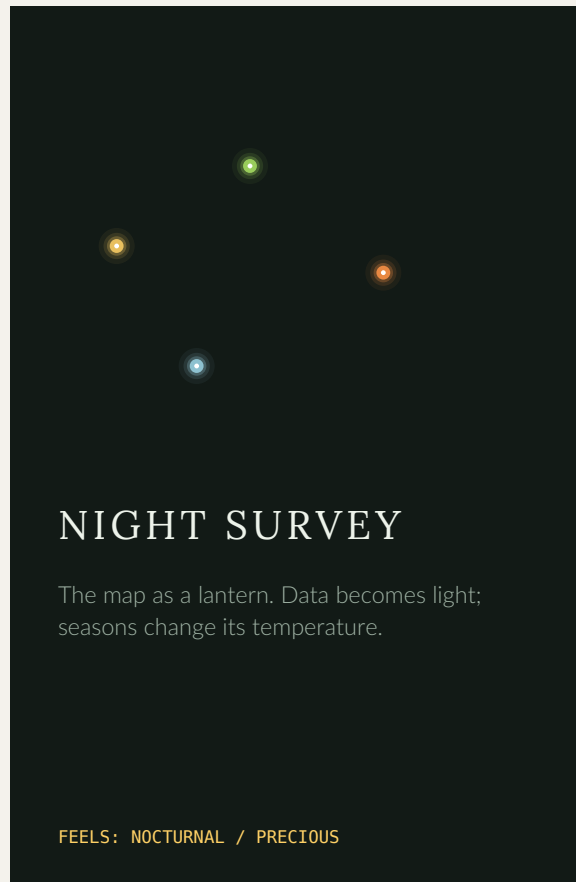
05 The identity should know the season.

Adaptive identities are the current; an almanac that visibly turns with the year is ours by right.

And one contract: if two directions could share a page unnoticed, one of them is wrong. The matrix on page 23 holds them apart.

THE THREE WORLDS

Three claims, side by side



Pigment Index

The interface is the color of the material.
Archive precision, living type.

FEELS: PRECISE / CURIOUS

Each is presented in five pages: the world, type and wordmark, color and season system, the map, and a material page with voice. Safety chips and the ethics line appear in all three -- they are the constants being dressed three ways.

DIRECTION I

Night Survey

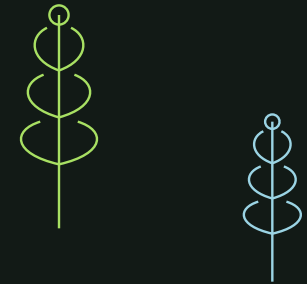
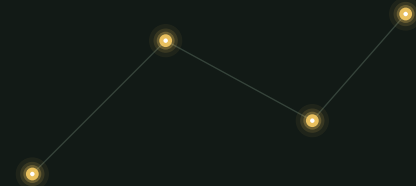
The map as a lantern.

Foraging's most charged hours are dusk and dawn, and the most compelling maps of the last decade are dark ones: firefly cartography, earth.nullschool, lights-at-night. Night Survey inverts the almanac -- ink becomes the field, paper becomes the light. The basemap is a deep spruce-black wood; every occurrence is a small lamp. Data stops being dots on paper and becomes something glowing and precious you lean toward.

MOTIFS

Firefly points. Smoked-glass panels. Constellation lines between related species. Season = the temperature of the light.

Precedents working here: firefly cartography, earth.nullschool, Emergence's dark immersive features. No one in the foraging or craft space owns the night.



ENGRAVED LIGHT-LINE SPECIMENS + FIREFLY DATA

DIRECTION I / WORDMARK + TYPE

CRAFT ALMANAC

LETTERSPACED LUMINOUS SERIF; THE LANTERN DOT MARKS 'NOW' ON EVERY SURFACE



DISPLAY

REC: GT ALPINA OR SELF MODERN (LUMINOUS HIGH-CONTRAST SERIF) / LORA STAND-IN

After dark, the riverbank

TEXT

REC: INTER OR SOHNE LEICHT / LATO LIGHT STAND-IN

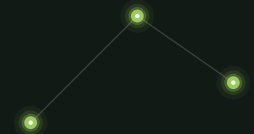
Quiet, highly readable, set generously on the dark ground.

LABELS / DATA

REC: IBM PLEX MONO / DEJAVU MONO STAND-IN

N 41.802 W 71.412 . SAMBUCUS . RIPE WK 24-28

Type behavior: display serif appears only in light-on-dark identity moments (masthead, mode names, species headings) where its contrast glows. Body and UI stay matte. Mono carries coordinates, weeks, and rule citations -- the survey voice.



DIRECTION I / COLOR + SEASON SYSTEM

A dark core; seasons change the temperature of the light

STABLE CORE



SPRUCE FIELD
#121A16

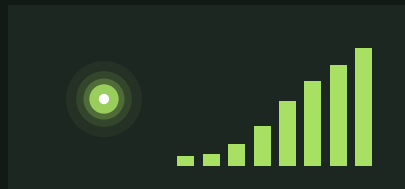
PANEL
#1C2721

LIGHT TEXT
#EDF3EA

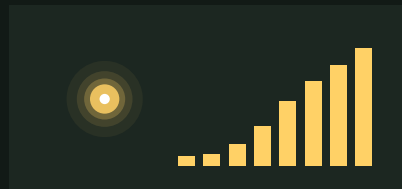
MUTED
#9DB0A2

HAIRLINE
#2E3B33

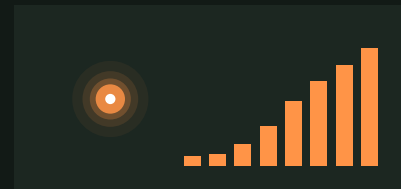
SEASONAL LIGHT (ONE VARIABLE SET PER SEASON)



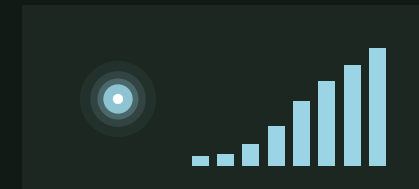
SPRING . WILLOW GLOW



SUMMER . LANTERN GOLD

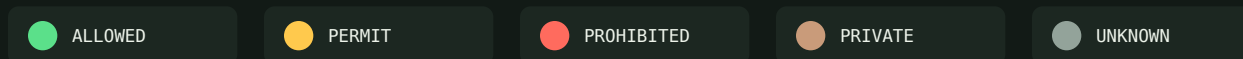


AUTUMN . EMBER

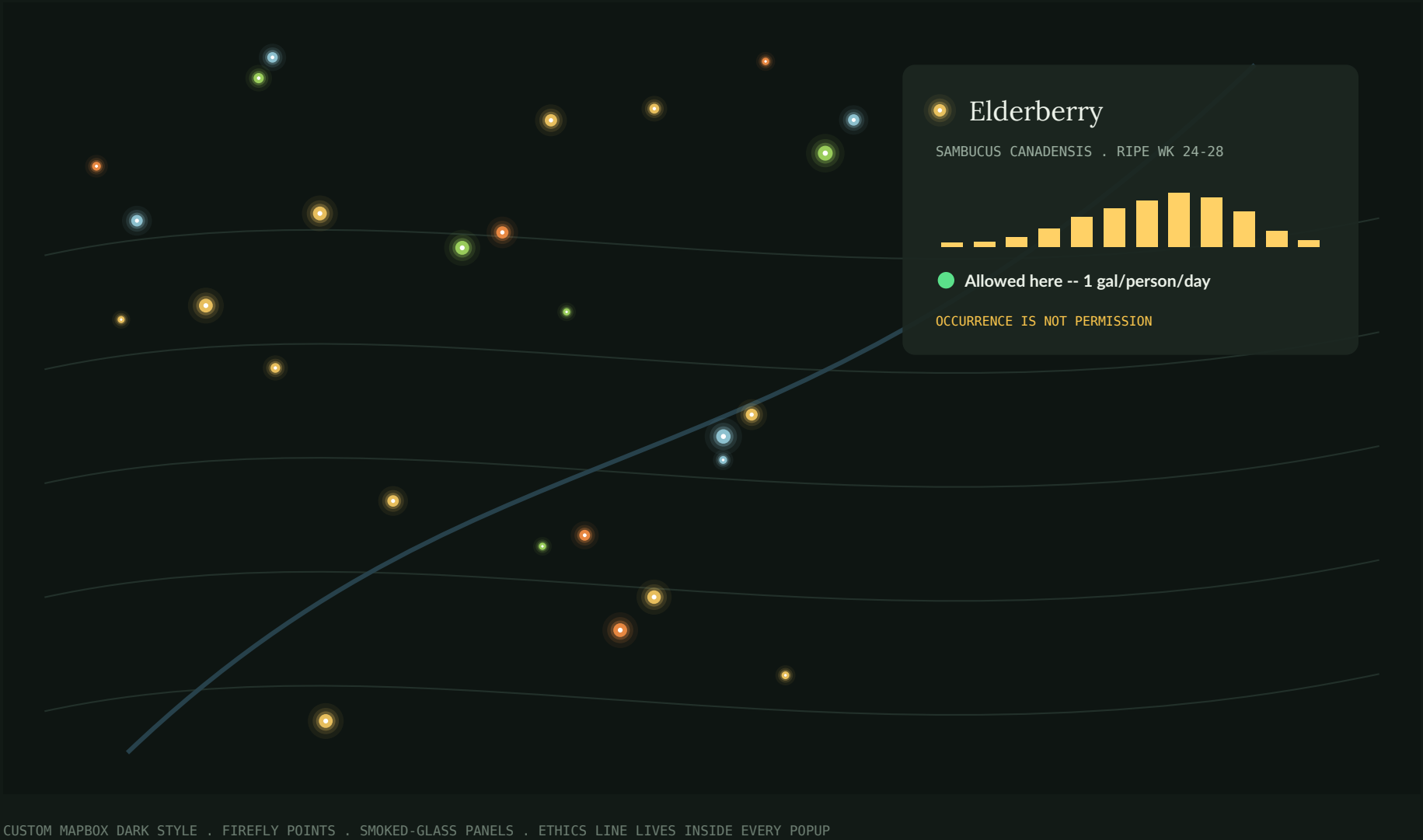


WINTER . ICE LIGHT

ACCESS STATUS ON THE DARK GROUND -- TUNED FOR LUMINANCE CONTRAST, CVD-CHECKED



Seasons rotate the color temperature of every glow: pale willow light in April, ember orange in October, ice blue in January. One CSS variable set per season; the dark core never changes.

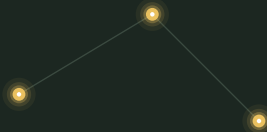


CUSTOM MAPBOX DARK STYLE . FIREFLY POINTS . SMOKED-GLASS PANELS . ETHICS LINE LIVES INSIDE EVERY POPUP

DIRECTION I / A MATERIAL PAGE + VOICE

ELDERBERRY

NO. 012 . FOOD + INK . RIPE WK 24-28



SEASON HISTOGRAM -- DATA AS THE HERO IMAGE

GATHER GENTLY: ABUNDANT . LEAVE STEMS FOR BIRDS

VOICE

Elderberry, riverbank colony. The umbels ripen this week; come at golden hour and take one gallon, no more. The light will show you which are ready.

HOW IT TEACHES

Projector-friendly 'daybreak' theme for classrooms; the dark theme returns after sunset. Survey-grade mono data keeps research credibility; the glow keeps the wonder.

RISK

Dark UI in a bright classroom. Mitigation: a 'daybreak' inverse theme keyed to local sunrise -- the almanac literally turns its lamp off in the morning. Both themes ship from one variable set.

DIRECTION II

OVERPRINT

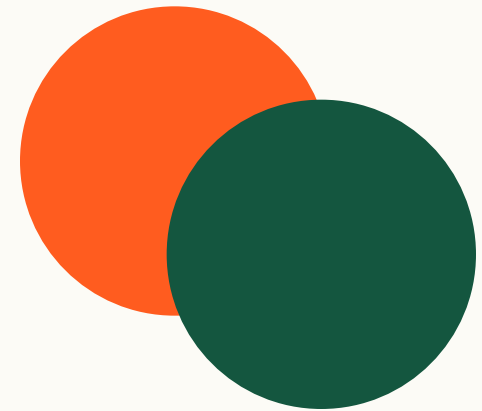
A community print shop, two inks at a time.

The contemporary craft signal is not parchment -- it is the risograph studio: fluorescent ink, bold cuts, small batches, hands visible in the work. Overprint treats every season as a new two-ink edition. Two spot colors per season overprint to make a third; type runs at poster scale; illustration is stencil-cut with halftone shading. The site feels like a print shop that teaches -- because that is what it is.

MOTIFS

Two-ink overprints. Slight misregistration. Halftone shading. Numbered broadside steps. Poster-scale wood type.

Precedents working here: RISOTTO and the riso-studio wave, broadside poster culture, 2026's poster-scale type. The closest world to the craft processes the site teaches.



STENCIL CUTS + HALFTONE + OVERPRINT

DIRECTION II / WORDMARK + TYPE

CRAFT ALMANAC

STACKED WOOD TYPE, TWO SEASONAL INKS, MISREGISTERED ON PURPOSE; RE-INKED FOUR TIMES A YEAR

DISPLAY

REC: ARCHIVO BLACK (FREE) OR MANUKA (KLIM) / LATO BLACK STAND-IN

TAKE A LITTLE. LEAVE THE REST.

TEXT / UI

REC: SPACE GROTESK / POPPINS STAND-IN

Friendly geometric body that stays out of the ink's way.

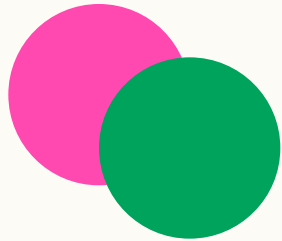
LABELS

REC: SPACE MONO / DEJAVU MONO STAND-IN

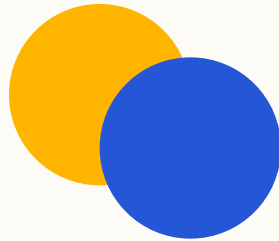
EDITION 26-SUMMER . SUNFLOWER x COBALT

Type behavior: headlines earn poster scale only on identity surfaces and project broadsides; rules, access statuses, and species data are always set quiet and plain. The contrast between shout and whisper is the brand.

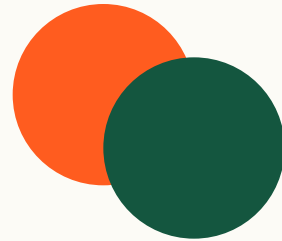
FOUR EDITIONS A YEAR, TWO INKS EACH



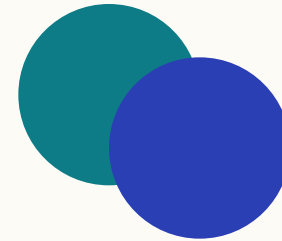
SPRING . FLUORO PINK X LEAF
OVERLAP #8C3550



SUMMER . SUNFLOWER X COBALT
OVERLAP #2E8540

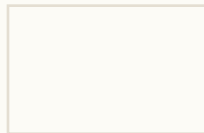


AUTUMN . FLUORO ORANGE X FOREST
OVERLAP #84321B

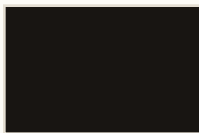


WINTER . TEAL X ULTRAMARINE
OVERLAP #14365C

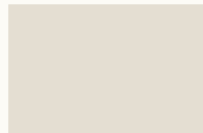
PRESS CONSTANTS



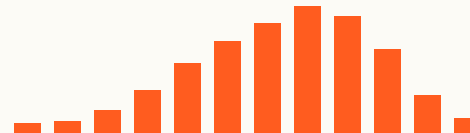
PRESS WHITE



TEXT INK



HAIRLINE

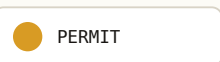


DATA PRINTS IN THE SEASON'S INK

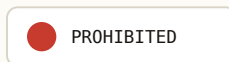
ACCESS STATUS -- A FIXED NEUTRAL SYSTEM, NEVER SEASONAL, ALWAYS ON WHITE CHIPS



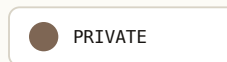
ALLOWED



PERMIT



PROHIBITED



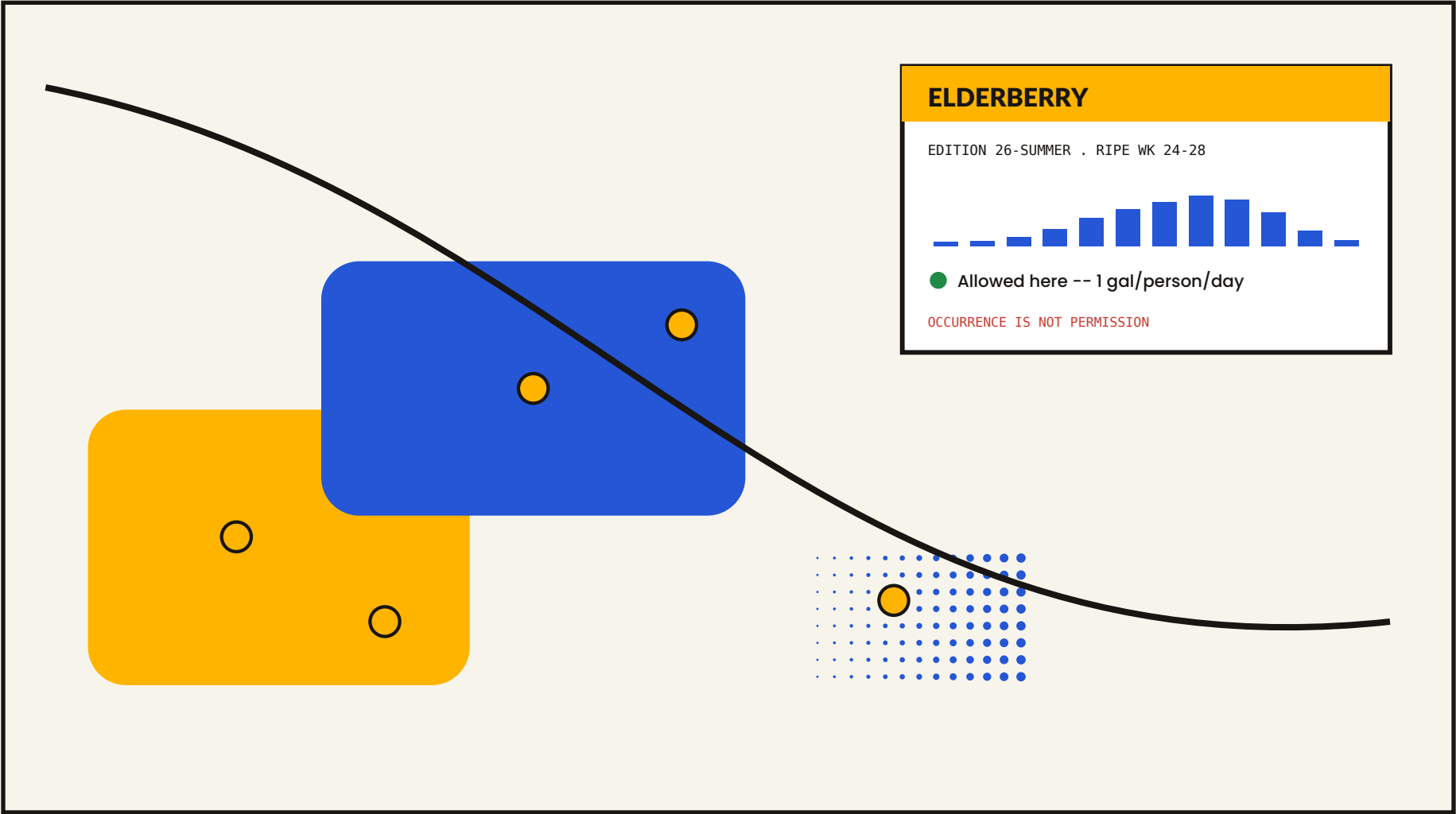
PRIVATE



UNKNOWN

Each season is a two-ink pair that overprints to a third color -- four small palettes a year instead of one large one. CSS: two accent variables plus mix-blend-mode: multiply. The paper white and text ink never change.

DIRECTION II / THE MAP



PAPER BASEMAP PUSHED TO POSTER: SPOT-INK LAND SHAPES, HALFTONE WATER, RINGED DATA, LABEL POPUPS

OAK GALL INK

A BROADSIDE IN SIX STEPS . EDITION 26-AUTUMN

- 01** GATHER fallen galls -- hole means the wasp has left
- 02** CRUSH and soak, three days
- 03** ADD iron water; watch it turn
- 04** STRAIN through cloth
- 05** BIND with gum arabic
- 06** WRITE something worth keeping



VOICE

INK FROM OAK GALLS -- A BROADSIDE IN SIX STEPS. Gather fallen galls only; the wasp has left when the hole shows. Step one is on the press now.

HOW IT TEACHES

Project guides are literal broadsides -- printable, pin-up-able, classroom-native. Steps at poster scale read across a room. The quiet text layer holds the rigor and the rules.

RISK

Loud enough to drown safety messaging. Mitigation: status colors are a fixed neutral system that never joins the seasonal inks, always on white chips; rules text always set quiet.

DIRECTION III

Pigment Index

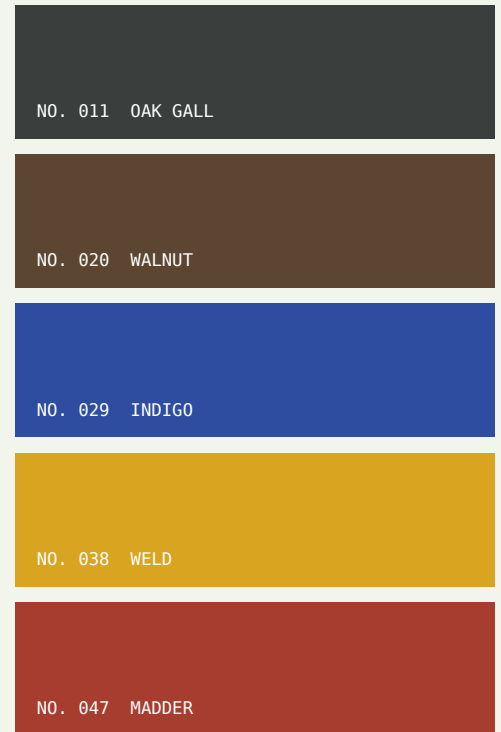
The interface is the color of the material.

Every material on the map is also a color you can make: ink, dye, pigment, finish. Pigment Index organizes the whole identity around that fact, the way the Mushroom Color Atlas lets its swatches do the navigating. Big fields of material-derived color carry the interface; an exposed index grid, mono specimen labels, and a variable display face whose softness turns with the season keep it precise but alive. Cool, contemporary, archival -- never cream, never antique.

MOTIFS

Pigment fields as navigation. Index numbers. Exposed hairline grid. Mono labels. A display face that softens in spring and sharpens in winter.

Precedents working here: the Mushroom Color Atlas's swatch-first navigation, archive catalogs, 2026's adaptive identities. The research-grade direction -- and the craft is in the color itself.



PIGMENT FIELDS AS NAVIGATION

Craft Almanac

CA--026

WORDMARK + RUNNING INDEX NUMBER; THE MARK IS A CATALOG ENTRY THAT UPDATES WITH THE YEAR

ONE VARIABLE FACE, FOUR SEASONS (FRAUNCES SOFT/WONK AXES -- STAND-INS SHOWN)

Almanac

SPRING . SOFT, OPEN

Almanac

SUMMER . FULL, EASY

Almanac

AUTUMN . WONKY, RIPE

Almanac

WINTER . SHARP, UPRIGHT

TEXT / UI

REC: PUBLIC SANS OR SOHNE / LATO STAND-IN

Plain, legible, friendly -- the archive's quiet librarian.

LABELS / DATA

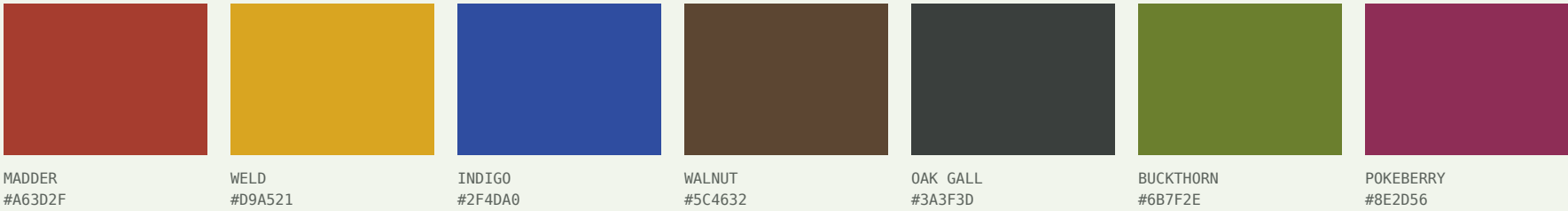
REC: IBM PLEX MONO / DEJAVU MONO STAND-IN

NO. 047 . JUGLANS NIGRA . HULLS . WK 40-44 . LIGHTFAST 7/8

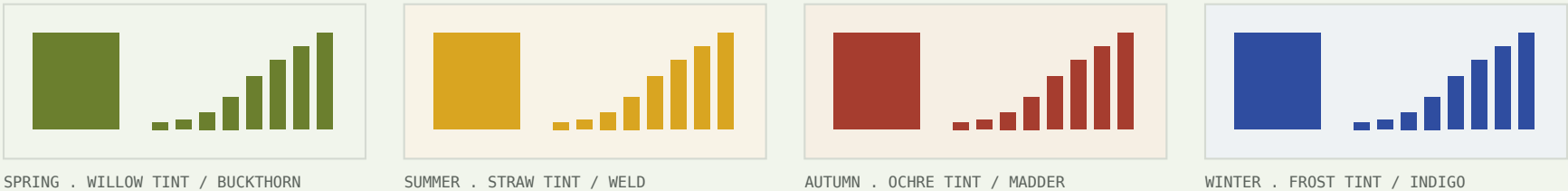
Type behavior: the display face is the one living thing in a disciplined system -- its softness drifts with the season via CSS font-variation-settings, the almanac premise expressed in the letterforms themselves. Everything else holds still.

Material-derived pigments; the ground turns with the year

THE PIGMENT SHELF -- EVERY COLOR IS A RECIPE A USER CAN MAKE



SEASONAL GROUND TINTS + LEAD PIGMENT (ONE VARIABLE EACH)

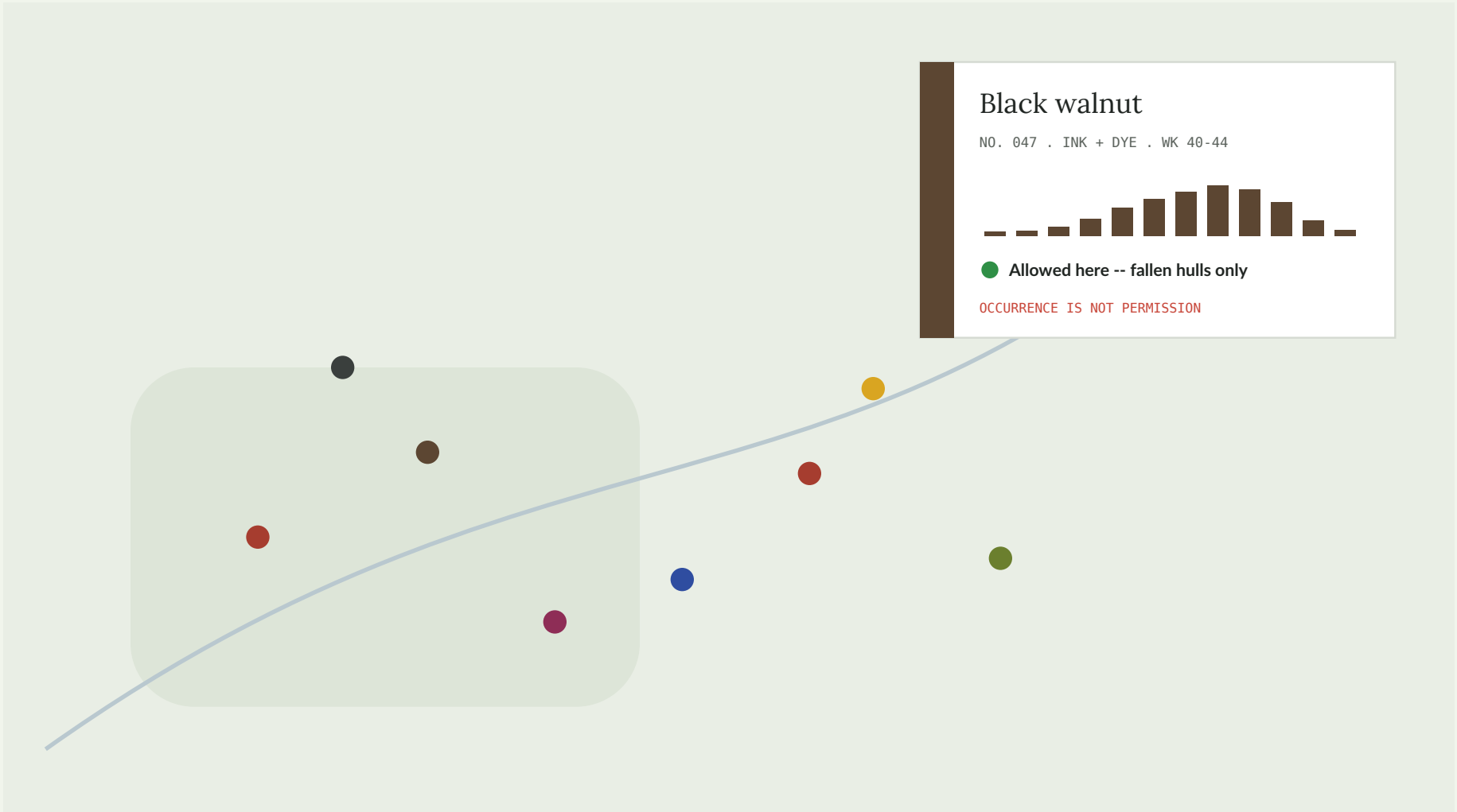


ACCESS STATUS -- THE ONE PALETTE PIGMENTS NEVER TOUCH; SEMANTIC, FIXED, CVD-CHECKED



Two seasonal mechanisms, both one-variable cheap: the page ground takes a faint seasonal tint, and the display face's variable axes (SOFT/WONK) drift across the year -- soft and open in April, sharp and upright in January.

DIRECTION III / THE MAP



DESATURATED GREY-GREEN BASEMAP; EVERY OCCURRENCE RENDERED IN ITS MATERIAL'S OWN PIGMENT; SPINE-TAB POPUPS

Black walnut

NO. 047 . JUGLANS NIGRA . INK + DYE



WOOL . IRON SHIFTS DARKER



SILK . IRON SHIFTS DARKER



COTTON . IRON SHIFTS DARKER



LINEN . IRON SHIFTS DARKER



OCT IS YOUR MONTH

Margin note: the year's first hard frost drops the hulls for you. Gloves on; the stain is the lesson.

GATHER GENTLY: FALLEN HULLS ONLY . ABUNDANT

VOICE

No. 047 -- Black walnut. Hull to ink in two days; wear gloves, stain is the point. Histogram shows October is your month. Occurrence is not permission -- check the parcel rule first.

HOW IT TEACHES

Reads like a lab reference: index numbers cite cleanly, dye tables print cleanly, and the pigment shelf doubles as a curriculum -- each color is an assignment.

RISK

Minimal can tip sterile, which the brief bans. Mitigation: material color at generous scale, literary margin notes in the voice, and the seasonal type drift -- warmth from the system, not from ornament.

SIDE BY SIDE

The distinctness contract, checked

	I . NIGHT SURVEY	II . OVERPRINT	III . PIGMENT INDEX
Ground	spruce-black night	press white + fluoro ink	seasonal pale tints
Display type	luminous serif, letterspaced	wood-type black, stacked	variable serif that drifts
Imagery lead	data as light	stencil cuts + halftone	pigment fields + tables
Map	firefly on custom dark style	poster paper, spot-ink shapes	grey-green, pigment dots
Season turn	temperature of the light	new two-ink edition	ground tint + type softness
Wordmark	letterspaced + lantern dot	stacked overprint	catalog entry CA--026
Feels like	dusk walk with a lamp	print shop open night	an archive you can touch
Nearest precedent	firefly / nullschool	RISOTTO / broadsides	Mushroom Color Atlas
Biggest risk	dark UI by day	loudness vs. safety	minimal tips sterile

Constants in all three: safety chip semantics, the ethics line inside every popup, CSS-variable implementation, no photography, both imagery engines owned.

RISKS + MITIGATIONS

Where each world can fail, and the guard rails

I . NIGHT SURVEY

Dark UI in a bright classroom. Mitigation: a 'daybreak' inverse theme keyed to local sunrise -- the almanac literally turns its lamp off in the morning. Both themes ship from one variable set.

Also: glow effects must stay performant -- pure CSS shadows and pre-tinted SVG, no canvas filters. Accessibility audit on every season's dark palette.

II . OVERPRINT

Loud enough to drown safety messaging. Mitigation: status colors are a fixed neutral system that never joins the seasonal inks, always on white chips; rules text always set quiet.

Also: misregistration is an identity gesture, never applied to maps, charts, or safety UI. Print styles ship with the broadsides.

III . PIGMENT INDEX

Minimal can tip sterile, which the brief bans. Mitigation: material color at generous scale, literary margin notes in the voice, and the seasonal type drift -- warmth from the system, not from ornament.

Also: variable-font loading is the one new asset weight; subset aggressively and fall back to the static face.

Shared guard rail: all three keep the current information architecture (modes, filters, popups, rules). This is a reskin of meaning, not a rebuild of behavior -- CSS variables, fonts, SVG, and one Mapbox style each.

Five asks

01 Which world?

Pick a lead direction -- or rule one out. Round 3 prototypes the survivor(s) live on the design branch.

02 How far from daylight paper?

Night Survey is the boldest break. Is a dark-first site viable for your teaching, given the daybreak theme?

03 Loudness budget.

Overprint at full volume, or Overprint's ink logic at editorial volume? Both are buildable; they feel different.

04 Seasonal mechanics.

Light temperature, two-ink editions, or tint + type drift -- which seasonal turn should the site lead with? (They can be mixed, carefully.)

05 Cross-borrows.

Anything a direction owns that you want regardless (firefly map, broadside guides, pigment shelf, variable-type seasons)? Name it and Round 3 carries it.

Process per the brief: converge on a direction in deck form, then build it as a live prototype on design/relaunch before anything touches main.